

## THE CHASSIS

A couple of years ago, if you thought a *good* motherboard was a luxury, we'd have forgiven you. Today, because of the slew of motherboard vendors who have flooded our markets over the last year, it's not any more—in terms of neither availability nor cost. We're not talking about just a small brand office in a couple of metros, but actual market availability.

We've busted another myth this year as well—motherboards based on the latest chipsets aren't as expensive as you'd expect them to be anymore! Vendors in India have traditionally categorised the market into two sections—those who can afford good boards and those who can't. The former section of PC users have been wooed with expensive *premium* offerings, while the latter section have to be content with value boards that are wafer-thin on features. This time round, we've truly seen something for everyone, and it's you—the customers—who are to be thanked for this!

You've become more discerning and you know what you want—during one of our sojourns to Lamington Road (Mumbai's hardware hub) we were pleased to see customers actually asking for boards on the basis of chipsets and brands. In fact, they'd Googled up the specifications and features of the boards they were interested in, and weren't moved by the shopkeeper who was trying to placate them with other offerings.

## INTEL P35-BASED MOTHERBOARDS

Intel's P35 chipset is their replacement for the older (and excellent) P965 chipset. Motherboards based on this chipset have native support for the 1333 MHz FSB that the new Core 2 Duo processors (E6x50) support. Additionally, they will also support the upcoming 45 nm Penryn. The memory controller supports DDR3, but Intel has left it to vendors to decide whether to provide DDR2 or DDR3 slots. The Southbridge—ICH9R—is also rumoured to be better; the P965's used the ICH8R.

### Features

Of the 15 boards in this category, we chose to compare only 14 on the same platform. The ASUS P5K3 Premium is a luxury even among luxurious boards (a Bentley among Mercs, if you will). It's the first board we've seen embedded with 2 GB of DDR3 memory—there are no memory slots. There's enough copper on the board for it to be used as a very heavy albeit costly weapon! Priced at Rs 70,000, this is a sinful indulgence—not to mention the sad fact that you cannot upgrade to 4 GB of RAM whatever you do!

All the ASUS P35 boards had excellent layouts and were exceptionally well built, with good quality components. We had one major grouse—



Traditional SATA connects interfere with bigger graphics cards and cause clutter

the first two SATA ports are blocked (though not completely so as to prevent their use) by large graphics cards like our 8800GTX. ASUS provides dual Gigabit LAN ports and integrated Wi-Fi on their Deluxe and Premium boards. The ASUS Blitz series is part of their Republic of Gamers franchise, which means they are more overclocker-friendly than the other boards, have a lot of mostly flashy and sometimes useful LEDs, and cost, well, a lot (Rs 17,000 and above)! The Blitz motherboards also had water blocks on the Northbridge cooling solution for extreme tweakers who plan on using liquid cooling solutions. Furthermore, the Blitz boards have a special LCD screen to display the POST (Power-on Self-test) status—instead of the regular hexadecimal POST display, ASUS offers an LCD that converts the hexadecimal value to regular English—nifty, but you pay a premium for this feature.

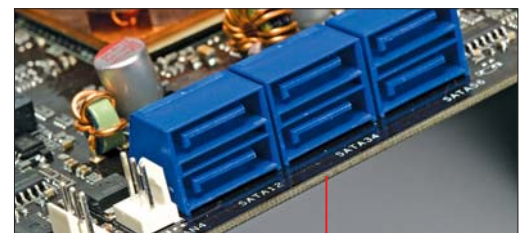
Abit's IP-35 Pro Off Limits has a very useful CMOS reset switch on the back panel (something ASUS does with a button on their Blitz series).

The IP-35 Pro is very overclocker-friendly—very well laid out and numerous BIOS options. It even has a HEX error code poster to make debugging easier.

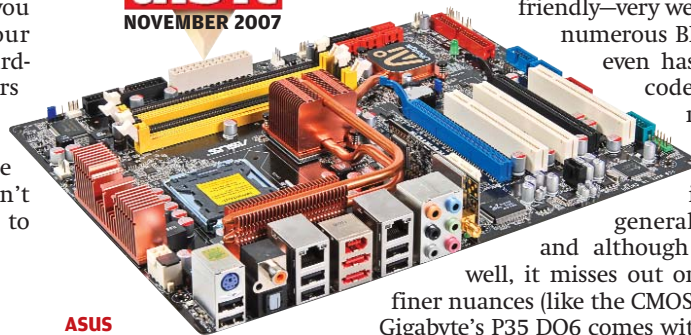
The IP-35 E is aimed at the general audience—and although it overclocks well, it misses out on some of the finer nuances (like the CMOS reset button).

Gigabyte's P35 DQ6 comes with a lot of copper in the form of an elaborate heat-pipe solution that we found downright ugly. Compared to the ASUS P5K Deluxe and Premium—which dissipate the same amount of heat and are aimed at the same audience (overclockers)—we don't see the need for such a massive cooling solution. It also boasts of Gigabyte's "6 Quad" features—though this is more marketing speak than anything significant. While a 12-phase power supply to the CPU sounds good, this is a novelty rather than a very useful feature, and a six- or eight-phase design will do just fine. We did like the high quality, solid state capacitors, which should improve durability significantly.

MSI's P35 Diamond is another good looker (though the ASUS boards definitely look better). The BIOS also has a very annoying setting for increasing voltages—you have to keep using the plus (+) and minus (-) keys to change them. BioStar's P35 doesn't allow the CAS latency to go lower than 5—this is a bane for overclockers,



SATA ports that face outwards like this prevents cable clutter and won't foil larger graphics cards



**ASUS P5K Premium**  
The ultimate premium board